FUNDA REPORT

Research|LLM: Step-level Routing Within Tasks Could Create Headwind for LLM Revenue

Step-level routing could cut frontier API spend 5–8% soon, creating a revenue headwind for LLM labs.

摘要

Step-level routing could move from pilots to broader production over the next few quarters as enterprises intensify token budgeting and agent workflows split tasks into many model calls. In FUNDA's 20-task finance test, four-model routing matched Opus-only 95% first-pass accuracy at ~28% lower cost and ~68% below Fable-only. Under full adoption, within-lab routing could cut frontier API revenue 20–25%; at 20–30% adoption, the near-term headwind is ~5–8%.

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Executive Summary

1. As we have shared in our tokenomics survey series, token budgeting has become standard practice among enterprises, and routing is a popular way to control spend. But most routing today is **task-level** and rule-based: gateways split traffic by weight, load, latency or availability, while apps and agents tend to tie each prompt or workflow to one model upfront.

2. Where we differ from consensus: we think **step-level routing** will move from early pilots into broader production use soon. The cost pressure we see in our tokenomics survey will push enterprises to route within tasks. A complex task runs in one of two ways: as a chain of model calls by a single agent (planning, searching, reading, coding, formatting, checking), or split by a main agent into subtasks handed to subagents. We use "step-level routing" broadly for any within-task model selection, from the most granular form of routing every model call to routing by subtask or subagent; either way, the savings come from splitting a task across models rather than assigning one model end to end, as is common today.

3. Adoption is still early, but the pieces are falling into place: tools and routing methods are already available and still improving, and both surveyed enterprises and gateway experts are optimistic about adoption.

4. In our proprietary test on 20 finance research tasks (Section 3), step-level routing matched Opus-only first-pass accuracy at ~28% lower cost, and cost ~68% less than Fable-only. By our back-of-the-envelope estimate, under full adoption and holding all else constant, within-lab step-level routing alone could cut

frontier labs' API revenue by 20-25%; cross-lab routing (e.g., Fable for complex steps, DeepSeek for simple ones) could hit harder. If step-level routing adoption reaches 20-30% over the next few quarters, within-lab routing alone would be a ~5-8% headwind to frontier labs' API revenue. Real-world workloads and requirements are more complex, and actual savings will depend on how well routing is deployed and tuned, so our test results and sizing should be read as directional rather than precise.

Where Enterprises Are Today: Routing Is Common, but Mostly Traffic-Based at the Task Level

Routing Is Already Widely Used

In our Tokenomics survey, 47% of respondents (N=58) said they were either using model-routing tools (30%) or planning to build them (17%). These tools help control AI spending and may be developed in-house or provided by third parties or cloud PaaS platforms.

Deep|LLM: Enterprise AI Adoption Survey (Vol. 6) - In Our Sample: AI Spending Growth Expected to Slow; Routine Work Shifts to Lower-Cost Models

> "I estimate at least 20-30% of enterprises currently use model routing tools, and adoption is still growing fast. Adoption is driven by cost control, access to multiple models, reliability, observability, and governance. Within adopting enterprises, the share of traffic passing through a gateway typically rises to 50-60% within a couple of quarters of deployment."

——AI gateway provider B expert

How most surveyed enterprises route today: examples

Company	Step-level routing	Current routing setup
Large US pharma company	No	"We have created a **coaching skill** in Anthropic... but we don't have a centralized router... We have Opus for more orchestration, while Sonnet and Haiku for simpler tasks."
Telecom operator	No	"No dynamic routing. **Models are fixed per application at design stage, with one key per application**...An AI gateway on the cloud vendor's model platform tracks token costs by application and redacts sensitive prompt content…Opus for coding and complex tasks; Sonnet or Haiku for text-to-SQL after evaluation; lower-tier models also used for summaries."
Diversified holding company	No	"In-house intent-based routing for customer-facing smart hardware: **conversational requests go to cloud models, control commands to small on-device models**."

Source: FUNDA tokenomics survey

But most routing today is simple and static, operating at the task level: each prompt or task usually goes to one model end to end

- Default settings at the application/agent layer usually tie each prompt to one model: users typically pick a model per conversation in the Claude or ChatGPT app or CLI, and API calls specify one upfront. Labs' own auto options switch per message (ChatGPT Auto) or per phase (Claude Code's opusplan: Opus to plan, Sonnet to execute) rather than between steps. Subagents can run on different models, either preset in the subagent's configuration (e.g., in Claude Code) or specified by the user in the conversation, but in most use cases, especially outside coding, few enterprise users route at this level of detail, and enterprises may also preset which models each application can call, as in the telecom operator example above

How a task request flows through model routing



Source: FUNDA

- Routing used to be a side feature of gateways, built mainly for resiliency: until recently, both vendor gateway products and enterprises' own build-outs have centered on access control, governance, guardrails, security, observability and multi-model access. Routing has been added largely for system resiliency and remained traffic-based: requests are spread across models by preset weights, load, latency, usage or availability, without reading what the request contains

> "We are using AI gateways like TrueFoundry because we need model coverage, routing and fallback, rate limiting, budget controls, single sign-on, guardrails, an agent gateway, observability, and lifecycle management in one place."

——Leading online lending platform expert

Typical routing strategies in AI gateways: rules based on traffic conditions

Strategy	How it works	Main purpose
Round-robin (weighted)	Splits traffic by preset weights	Proportional traffic split
Consistent-hashing	Sends requests with the same header (e.g., user ID) to the same model	Session continuity, cache reuse
Least-connections	Picks the model with the most spare capacity	Overload prevention
Lowest-usage	Picks the model with the least tokens or spend used	Even token and spend distribution

Lowest-latency	Picks the model with the fastest recent responses	Faster responses
Priority	Sends all traffic to the top-priority model, falling back only if it is unavailable	Controlled failover

Source: Kong, FUNDA

- Agentic workloads have only recently gained broader traction: as enterprises move from Q&A to agents that execute tasks, a single request can trigger a chain of model and tool calls, creating the need to pick models within a task. Routing practices are still catching up
- Deployment is more demanding: step-level routing requires more deployment effort and finer-grained configuration and tuning than task-level routing. This makes ROI harder to demonstrate and slows enterprise rollout

> "Fine-grained step-level routing is much less mature, with adoption below 10% in my rough assessment. Step-level routing will certainly save money, but task-level routing is simpler, has ready-made tools and a very visible ROI, so enterprises adopt it first."

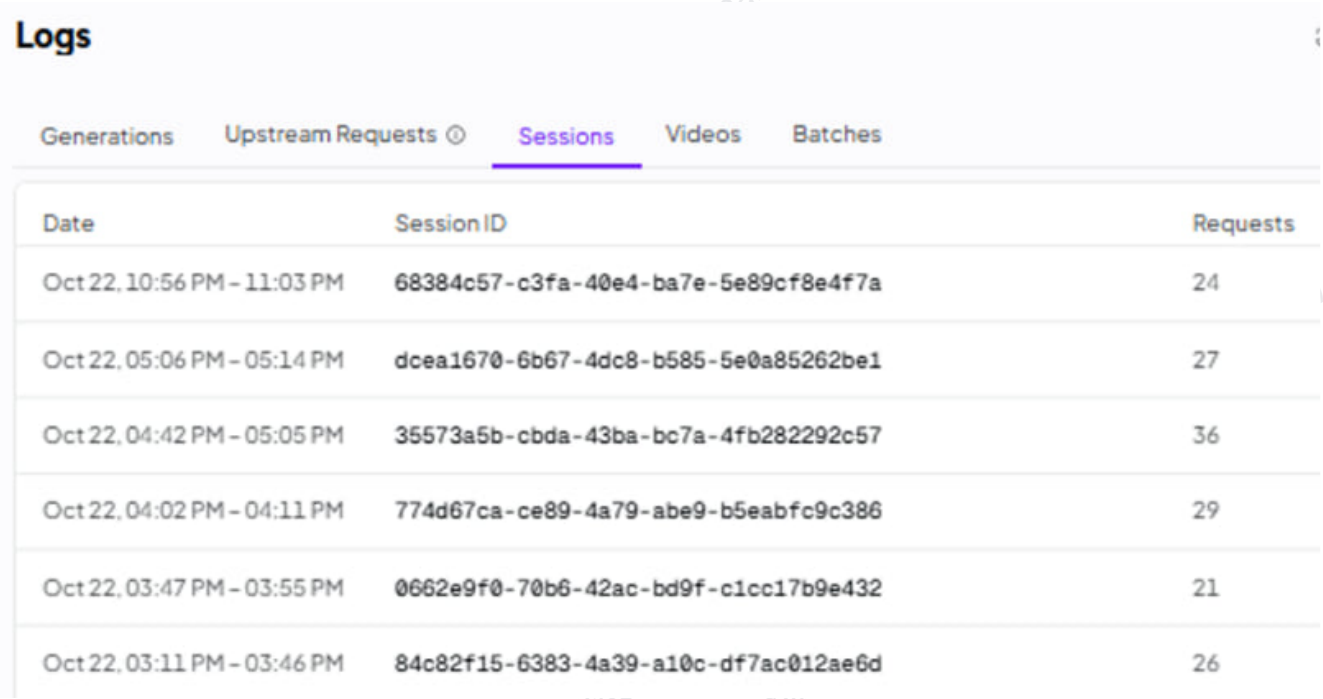
——AI gateway provider A expert

Step-Level Routing Is Now Broadly Workable on a Technical Level

Prerequisites Are in Place: Agents Run Tasks as Switchable Steps, and Routers Can See Each Step's Context

- Agents already break tasks into steps: agent tools such as Claude Code, Codex and Cursor run a single prompt as a loop of model calls (plan, call a tool, read the result, decide the next step). Across repeated runs of two sample tasks asking Claude to perform simple financial forecasting for a company and investment optimization analysis, each prompt generated 20–40 model calls/steps, any of which could, in principle, be routed to a different model
- Steps a cheaper model can handle: reading files, searching, extracting fields, summarizing tool output, formatting, writing boilerplate code
- Steps that still need a frontier model: architecture decisions, ambiguous requirements, debugging after repeated failures, final review

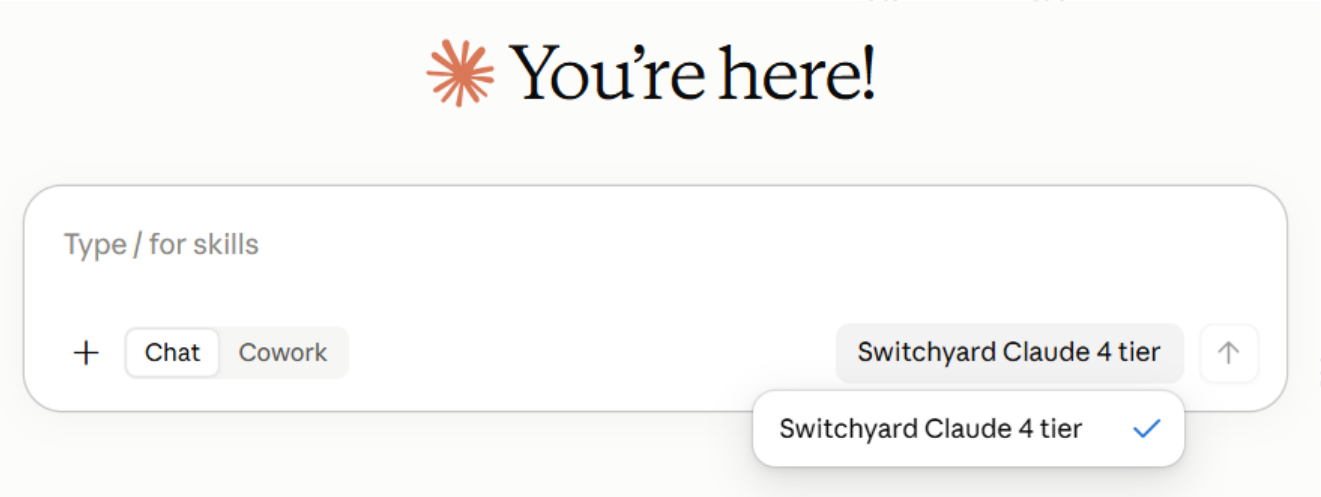
Number of model calls/steps (each row is one task prompt)



Source: OpenRouter logs, FUNDA

- A fixed model is often no longer required upfront: many agent products now let the model be chosen during the task rather than before it starts. Cursor, for example, ships a built-in router that picks the model for the user, and even Claude Desktop can be configured this way: after we connected it to a router (see Section 3 for setup), its model picker no longer lists individual models and shows a single auto-routing option instead. Enterprise admins can preconfigure this for users when setting up the gateway, so employees get auto-routing by default.

Claude Desktop model picker after configuration: a single auto-routing option replaces individual models



Source: Claude Desktop, FUNDA

- Routers can use the context supplied at each step: with stateless APIs, the agent manages conversation state and supplies each request's context—not necessarily the full history. Routers can use this context for step-level decisions; for example, Switchyard uses tool-error signals to trigger escalation

Tools and Methods Are Multiplying: Off-The-Shelf Tools and Ready-Made Routing Rules Are Already Available, and They Are Still Improving

- Both industry and academia are pushing step-level routing forward: over the past year, more advanced tools that route within a task have been launched, so enterprises can either switch on a packaged feature in their existing PaaS or gateway, or self-host an open-source router in their own environment. Academic research has also accelerated: since the start of 2026 we count more than 10 papers on switching models mid-task, more than half released since June, likely seeding newer routing methods that will make their way into commercial products

Selected dynamic step-level routing tools

Type	Product	Release/Update	Deployment / integration
CSP PaaS	Azure Model Router	Nov 2025	/
Gateway	OpenRouter Auto Router	Aug 2026: per-turn model re-selection	/
Gateway	LiteLLM Auto Router	Jul 2026: Beta	/
Gateway	Ramp Router.com	Aug 2026	/
Standalone router	Not Diamond Code	Aug 2026: early access	Works with any gateway or harness, incl. Claude Code
Standalone router	NVIDIA NeMo Switchyard	Aug 2026	Open-source; available on OpenRouter; LiteLLM / Kong integrations soon
Standalone router	Weave Router	May 2026	Open-source; connects to Claude Code or Codex
Standalone router	vLLM Semantic Router	Jan 2026: v0.1	Open-source
Agent product	Cursor Router	Jul 2026	/
Agent product	OpenAI Codex multi-agent v2	Aug 2026	/
Agent product	Hermes Agent (Nous Research)	2026 (plugin pre-release)	Open-source

Source: Microsoft Azure, OpenRouter, LiteLLM, Ramp, Not Diamond, NVIDIA, Weave, vLLM, Cursor, OpenAI, Nous Research, FUNDA

Selected recent papers on routing within a task

Title	Release date	Key method
AgentRouter: Heterogeneous Model Routing for Cost-Optimal Multi-Step Agentic Workflows	Sep 2026	A small classifier trained on labeled agent steps assigns each step to one of four model tiers, factoring in prior routing choices

RSI-Router: Evolving Subtask-Level LLM Routing and Skills for Cost-Efficient Agents	Sep 2026	Learns recurring subtasks from past runs to refine its routing rules, and adds model-specific skills to each model's prompt
Whose Turn Is It? Context-Guided Model Routing for Stateful Agents (Microsoft)	Oct 2026	Tests per-turn routing with and without session history, and the uneven cache cost of switching models up vs. down

Source: arXiv, FUNDA

- Ready-made routing rules are already available: routers combine a few types of rules, most of them available out of the box:

Rules	Selection method	Examples
Predefined rules	Route by step type or agent role, or by cues in the step's context, such as which tool is being called	LiteLLM's subtask router: route by tool call types
Judge or classifier models	A small model estimates whether a cheaper model can handle the request	AgentRouter's 12M-parameter classifier
Execution signals	Escalate when tool calls fail or progress stalls, and step back down once the hard part is done	NeMo Switchyard's escalation router
Hybrid	Combine the above	LiteLLM Auto Router v2

Source: LiteLLM, AgentRouter, NVIDIA, FUNDA

- Routing mechanisms are being refined to cut the cost of routing errors and of routing itself: a routing error can send a step to a model that cannot handle it, forcing a retry, or trigger an unneeded switch, each adding latency and context cost. Routers are being optimized in the following ways:

- Customize routing for each enterprise and learn from production: enterprises can add their own rules or labeled cases, and routers keep learning from past runs, e.g., Not Diamond trains a custom router on an enterprise's own prompts and quality scores, while RSI-Router mines recurring subtasks from past runs and refines its routing rules as it goes

- Route on richer signals than the prompt alone: judge each step on the task's history so far as well as the latest request. LiteLLM found that giving its classifier prior turns raised routing accuracy from 14% to 78% on a small set of chat follow-ups

- Price in the cost of switching models: prompt caches are model-specific, so a model must reprocess any history it has not cached itself (all of it on a first switch, only the new part when switching back within the cache lifetime), and prior thinking may not carry over. Whose Turn Is It? finds that a switch down to a cheaper model recovers that cost within two calls, while a switch up does not break even in its tests. Routing rules can therefore also weigh cache cost and favor natural handoff points, such as subagents, over mid-reasoning switches

- Use lighter judge models: use small classifiers or rules instead of an LLM judge, or reuse a decision across turns. The judge in our Section 3 test took ~5 seconds per step, versus under 5 ms for AgentRouter's 12M-parameter classifier

> "Reliable classification is harder: requests can mix topics and customers have highly specific routing policies, so 100% accuracy is unrealistic. One fix is to assign models to known workflow steps, e.g., steps two and three; another is to fine-tune the classifier for a specific industry. Context is less of a problem: the agent framework can pass it seamlessly between steps, with periodic summaries to limit its size."

——AI gateway provider A expert

> "Step-level routing requires upfront evaluation and configuration. Teams need to benchmark representative tasks across models and decide where to switch. Once set up, repeatable workflows can follow those rules automatically. Varied or unfamiliar tasks still rely more on in-house expertise."

——AI gateway provider D expert

Step-Level Routing Delivers Clear Cost Savings

Our Test on 20 Finance Research Tasks

- **A caveat first**: these results were produced by our industry research team without engineering support. We set up the configuration in a couple of hours following guidance from Claude and GPT, with no systematic tuning. The figures should be read as directional rather than precise: this is a small-scale test (20 tasks, two runs each), and production workloads with longer dependency chains and more varied tasks may be harder to route accurately. That said, our setup is not a ceiling: **it was configured by non-engineers, and in-house engineering teams or third-party vendors should be able to tune routing policies further**

Setup

- We built a test set of 20 common research tasks from easy to hard, such as finding facts in call notes and earnings reports and editing Excel models. Q1-10 provide source files; Q11-20 require web search. Each setup was run twice and the results averaged.

No.	Task	Difficulty
Q1	Interview information extraction	Easy
Q2	Earnings extraction and guidance comparison	Easy
Q3	Transaction terms extraction	Easy
Q4	Equity research data extraction	Easy
Q5	Annual report analysis and CAPEX calculation	Easy

Q6	Spreadsheet model interpretation	Easy
Q7	Fiscal quarter reconstruction	Moderate-Hard
Q8	Document content and formatting audit	Moderate-Hard
Q9	Compute demand scenario analysis	Moderate-Hard
Q10	Financial model stress testing and investment returns	Moderate-Hard
Q11	Public earnings research and guidance comparison	Easy
Q12	Monthly revenue aggregation	Easy
Q13	Channel revenue sharing and margin calculation	Easy
Q14	GPU specification comparison	Easy
Q15	Convertible note terms analysis	Easy
Q16	Treasury yield curve analysis	Easy
Q17	Historical relative valuation	Moderate-Hard
Q18	Gross margin adjustment and reconciliation	Moderate-Hard
Q19	GPU ownership versus rental cost analysis	Moderate-Hard
Q20	Free cash flow and finance lease analysis	Moderate-Hard

Source: FUNDA

- Claude Desktop Chat provides the agent layer and user interface: we submit task prompts in Chat, and its runtime manages conversation context and tool execution. Switchyard provides the routing layer, running locally in WSL. FUNDA AI Gateway (our internal gateway) provides the API access layer, forwarding requests to the selected model with its configured effort level.
- We use Switchyard's custom mode with a tailored routing policy that assigns four Claude model tiers to different levels of task difficulty. Each model is explicitly configured to use its Claude API default effort level for an apples-to-apples comparison. All setups, including single-model baselines, ran with default prompt-caching settings; reported costs are billed API costs, so any cache reprocessing after model switches is already reflected in the totals. GPT-6 Luna serves as thse judge model: before every model call, it evaluates the next step using the task and recent context and selects the cheapest adequate tier, so the model can switch from one call to the next. The judge sits outside the routing pool: it only makes routing decisions and never executes task steps

Model	Effort	Task allocation
Haiku 5.5	Medium	Extraction, formatting, simple arithmetic, routine file/tool operations.

Sonnet 5.5	High	Standard coding, debugging, research synthesis, straightforward comparisons and calculations.
Opus 5.5	Medium	Difficult reasoning, complex architecture, major contradictions, complex multi-source comparisons and multi-step calculations, replanning after substantive failures, and final requirements review.
Fable 5.1	High	Exceptionally difficult unresolved problems, especially after substantive Opus-level failures.

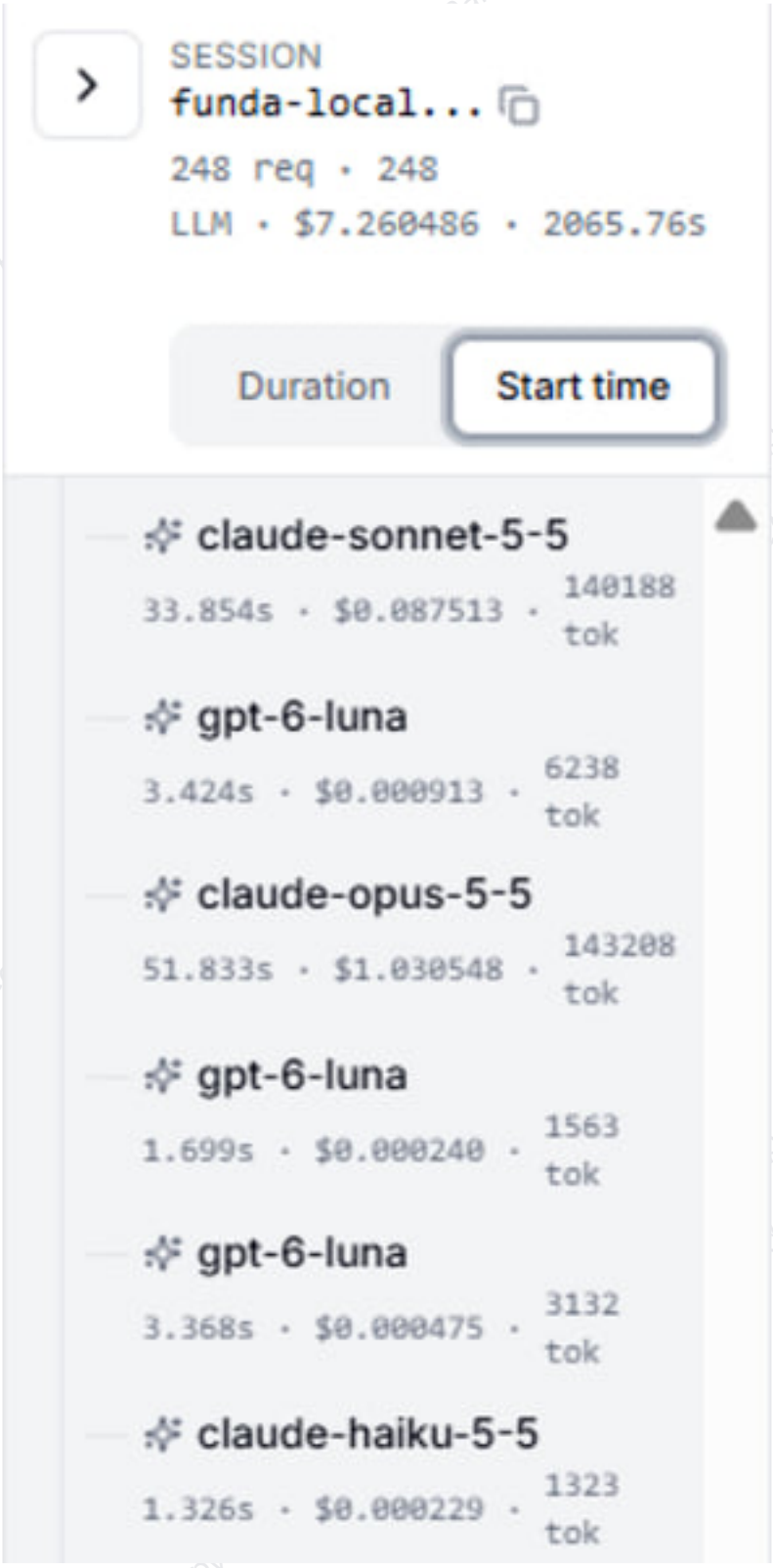
Source: FUNDA

- We did not test cross-lab routing (e.g., adding DeepSeek models), as our test environment, Claude Desktop, requires additional configuration to support non-Claude models, but it is technically feasible. Also, our test covers the call-by-call form of step-level routing; the subagent form (e.g., an Opus main agent delegating to cheaper subagents) also counts under our definition but may yield different savings

Findings

- Step-level routing worked with no manual intervention: we sent a single task prompt, with no instructions on how to break the task down or which model to use at each step, and the router picked a model for each step and switched between them without switching errors or manual handoffs. The screenshot below shows part of the model-call sequence from one of our two routing runs, in which all 20 benchmark tasks were submitted in a single prompt; each row represents one model call.

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Source: FUNDA

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- Routing matched frontier-level accuracy at lower cost: routing and Opus-only both scored 95% first-pass accuracy and Fable-only 100%, versus 83% for Sonnet-only and 73% for Haiku-only. Routing cost ~28% less than Opus-only and ~68% less than Fable-only, net of the extra cache reprocessing from model switches and of judge calls, as both are included in billed costs. Sonnet-only and Haiku-only cost less but missed 17% and 27% of tasks on the first pass, and production failures must be caught and rerun by hand. Routing captures much of the downgrading savings with far fewer reruns.

Test results

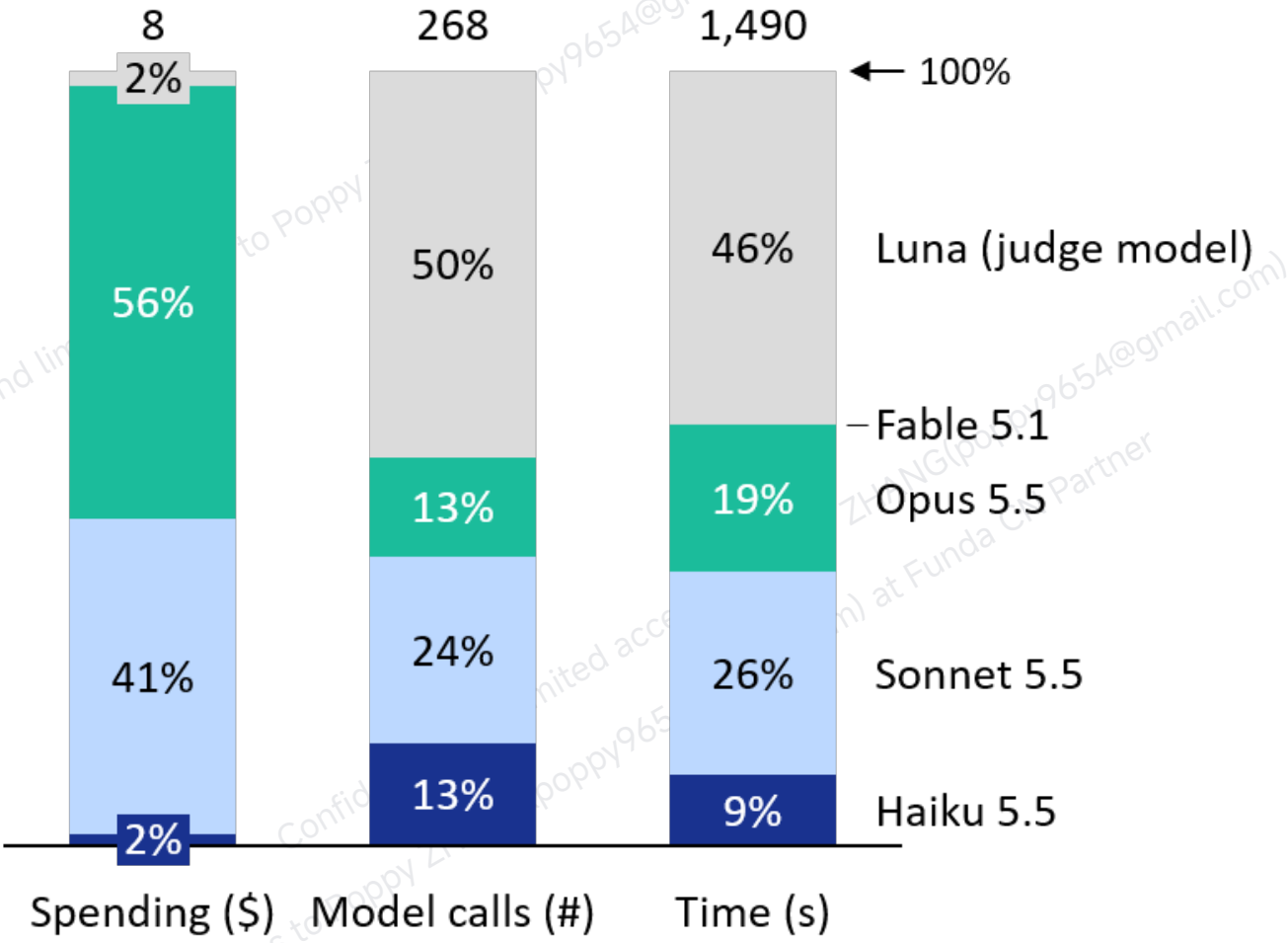
Model	Effort level	First-pass accuracy	API Cost ($)	Time (min)
Fable 5.1	High	100%	24.3	28
Opus 5.5	Medium	95%	10.8	23
Sonnet 5.5	High	83%	5.4	17
Haiku 5.5	Medium	73%	0.4	28
Four-model routing	Default effort per model	95%	7.7	25

Note: 1. First-pass accuracy is the number of tasks answered correctly on the first attempt divided by 20, averaged across two runs; 2. Cost and time are for getting every task right, including the first try plus any fixes; 3. Routing cost includes calls to the judge model, GPT-6 Luna. Source: FUNDA

- Only a small share of steps needed a top-tier model: the router never called Fable, and Opus handled ~13% of model calls (~26% excluding judge-model calls), though these accounted for ~56% of cost. Routing errors also caused little rework: tool results flagged an error in under 3% of model calls on average, a share that also includes network and environment errors, so rework from routing errors was lower still

Routing cost/request/time breakdown

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Source: FUNDA

- Latency is the main trade-off: routing took 25 minutes, slightly longer than Opus-only (23 minutes) and shorter than Fable-only (28 minutes), with judge calls (~5 seconds per step) accounting for ~46% of run time; excluding them, execution was ~40% faster than Opus-only, as cheaper models ran most steps faster. The judge overhead is high partly because we used an LLM judge (GPT-6 Luna) rather than a smaller, faster classifier

Other Empirical Evidence

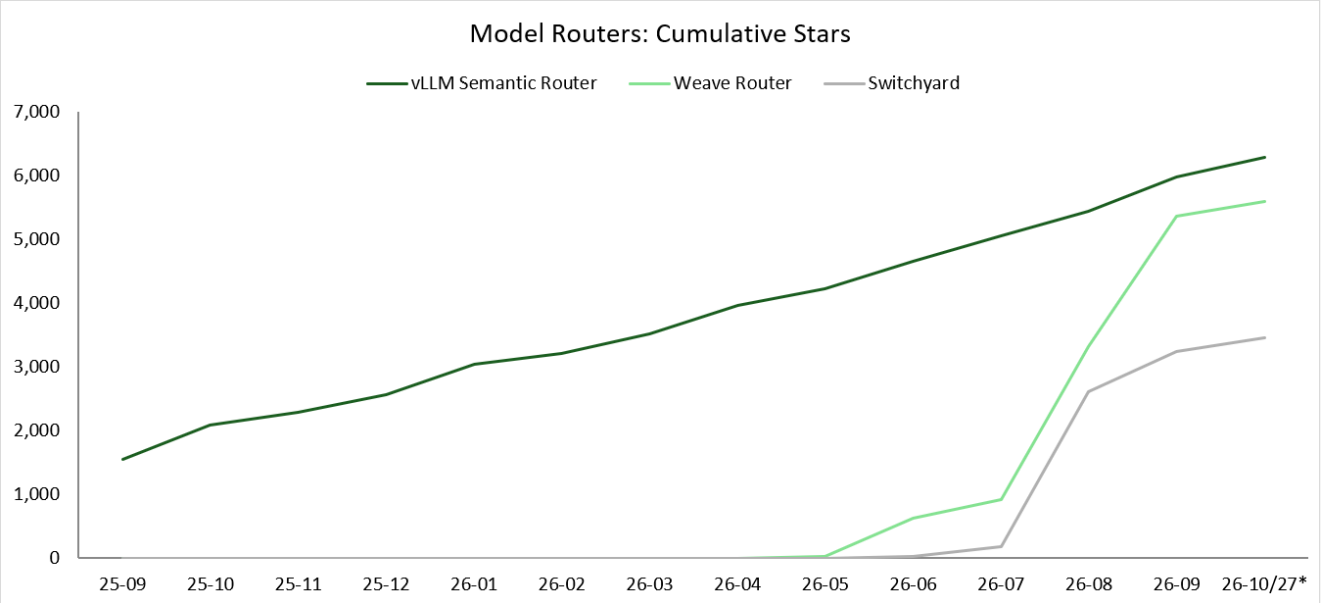
- Industry cases: LangChain ran Switchyard on 145 agent tasks, starting on NVIDIA's open-weight Nemotron 3.5 Lightning and escalating to Claude Opus 4.8; cost fell ~74% versus Opus-only, though accuracy fell 6ppts. LiteLLM's capability router, choosing only between Sonnet 5 and Opus 5 with prompt caching on, solved as many SWE-bench Verified tasks as Opus-only at 45% lower cost
- Academic papers: AgentRouter assigns each step to one of four model tiers, from frontier (GPT-4 class) down to minimal (7B-13B models), a 2024-era model ladder; it cut cost by 72% versus frontier-only while retaining 97% of quality. RSI-Router routes between DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash and Qwen3.5-9B, routing by recurring subtasks it learns from past runs; it cut cost by about half on average with higher scores across five agent benchmarks

Enterprises Have Started Early Adoption

Open-source routers are gaining traction

- GitHub stars indicate developer interest. Star counts likely understate usage, since users who access these routers through integrations (e.g., OpenRouter, AI gateways, hosted versions) do not need to star or fork the repo

Cumulative GitHub stars for step-level model routers



Note: Data as of Oct 27, 2026. Source: GitHub, FUNDA

Some of the Enterprises We Surveyed Have Already Started Building Dynamic Step-Level Routing Tools

Experts at AI Gateway Companies Are Broadly Positive About Future Adoption

> "Our vision is to build a model context gateway. A neutral front end and gateway would connect multiple back-end models—including locally deployed, hybrid, open, and closed models—so that each step can be routed to the appropriate model. It's not as easy as it sounds, but we're building it. Over time, an AI Agent trained on historical routing data could dynamically select the appropriate model."

——Leading investment bank expert

> "I estimate current adoption of step-level routing <10% in production, potentially approaching 25% in the coming quarters. Many gateways previously lacked automated routing but are now building it to meet customer demand as agents spread and workflows become multi-step. Customers increasingly want intelligent model selection that automatically matches each request's complexity to an appropriate model, instead of sending every prompt to an expensive, high-performance model."

——AI gateway provider B expert

> “If tasks can be broken down and routed to the appropriate models and demonstrate clear cost savings, enterprises will definitely be interested. This kind of tooling could flourish if products become mature and the cost benefit is clear enough to attract the actual buying group, including CXOs.”

——AI gateway provider C expert

Impact on Frontier Labs: A Rough Sizing

Labs May Be Able to Keep Routed Traffic within Their Own Ecosystems, but That Does Not Prevent Customers from Downgrading to Cheaper Models

A single API request rarely reveals whether it has been routed, making it difficult for labs to block router-based calls. **The larger risk is cross-lab routing,** in which simpler steps are sent to cheaper models from other providers. Labs have some ways to respond: switching providers can forfeit prompt-cache benefits, add latency and require new vendor reviews, while labs can compete through pricing, caching incentives and stronger task-specific performance. However, **retaining the traffic does not necessarily protect premium-tier usage;** customers can still route simpler steps to cheaper models within the same lab.

> “Model providers cannot prevent enterprises from using routing tools. Their possible response would be to improve the competitiveness of their models—for example, by training on more proprietary data and delivering stronger performance on specific tasks relative to alternatives. Lower pricing is another way.”

——AI gateway provider B expert

Under a Full-Adoption Scenario, Within-Lab Routing Could Reduce Spending on the Overall API Workload by 20–25%, Holding Task Demand and Pricing Constant

The actual near-term impact will depend on enterprise adoption and router quality. Lower costs could also encourage more usage, partly offsetting the revenue impact.

- **Our tier cuts draw on our own test plus industry and academic results** (some cross-lab, so used only as a magnitude check): Fable/Astra tier −50%, a rough assumption, using our test (~68% less than Fable-only, though the router never called Fable) and AgentRouter (~72% less than a GPT-4-class frontier tier) as references; Opus/Sol tier −30%, in line with our test (~28% less than Opus-only) and below LiteLLM (~45%) and LangChain (~74%); Sonnet/Luna tier −10%, as mid-tier tasks have fewer simple steps to hand down; Haiku/Terra tier 0%.
- **Each cut is net of shifts: it is the change in total spending on the tasks a tier runs today, wherever that spending ends up**. When routing moves a Fable task's simpler steps to other tiers, that spending is already netted into the Fable tier's −50%, so lower tiers' gains are not counted again on their own rows.

	Sep 2026 revenue %	Routing impact on revenue
OAI		
Total	**100%**	**-22%**
Others	12%	0%
Terra	5%	0%
Luna	32%	-10%
Sol	35%	-30%
Astra	17%	-50%
ANT		
Total	**100%**	**-25%**
Others	2%	0%
Haiku	3%	0%
Sonnet	26%	-10%
Opus	57%	-30%
Fable	10%	-50%

Note: Revenue mix by model tier is a proxy based on API spending on OpenRouter and Vercel. This data likely skews toward developers and startups; the tier mix in enterprise direct contracts and cloud marketplaces may differ. Source: OpenRouter, Vercel, FUNDA analysis

What to Watch

More Built-In Routing from Vendors Already in the Traffic Path

Cloud service providers, AI gateways and security vendors that already carry enterprise AI traffic could extend adoption beyond users of standalone or self-hosted routers. Some already offer relevant products, including Azure Model Router and OpenRouter Auto Router. Others are moving in: Palo Alto Networks acquired AI gateway provider Portkey, which offers rule-based routing and fallback, for Prisma AIRS in May 2026; Cloudflare launched its per-request Auto Router in September 2026. Built-in or not, routing will need to reflect each enterprise's actual workflows and leave room for customization

Enterprise Adoption Pace

Signals include auto-router usage on gateways and cloud platforms, changes in the model-tier mix of OpenRouter and Vercel spending, and whether agents enable routing by default. Our ongoing Tokenomics surveys will continue to track adoption and real-world performance, including whether latency and context loss remain manageable in longer production workflows. Adoption will likely start with subagent-level routing, which is simpler to set up, and move toward finer call-by-call switching where task complexity and early results justify it. Our ongoing tokenomics surveys will also keep an eye on adoption and real-world performance, including

whether latency stays acceptable and cache costs and rework stay as limited as in our test in longer production workflows

How Labs Respond

Potential responses include pricing that rewards customers for staying within one model family, such as deeper cache discounts and committed-spend plans; default-on native routing (such as opusplan-style settings); and terms-of-service restrictions on routed traffic. Labs have reasons to expand lab-native routing: it lifts margins on fixed-price subscriptions, keeps API traffic in-house rather than losing it to cross-lab routing (at some cost to premium-tier revenue). If so, labs' own defaults, not just enterprise routers, could drive part of the shift to cheaper models

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